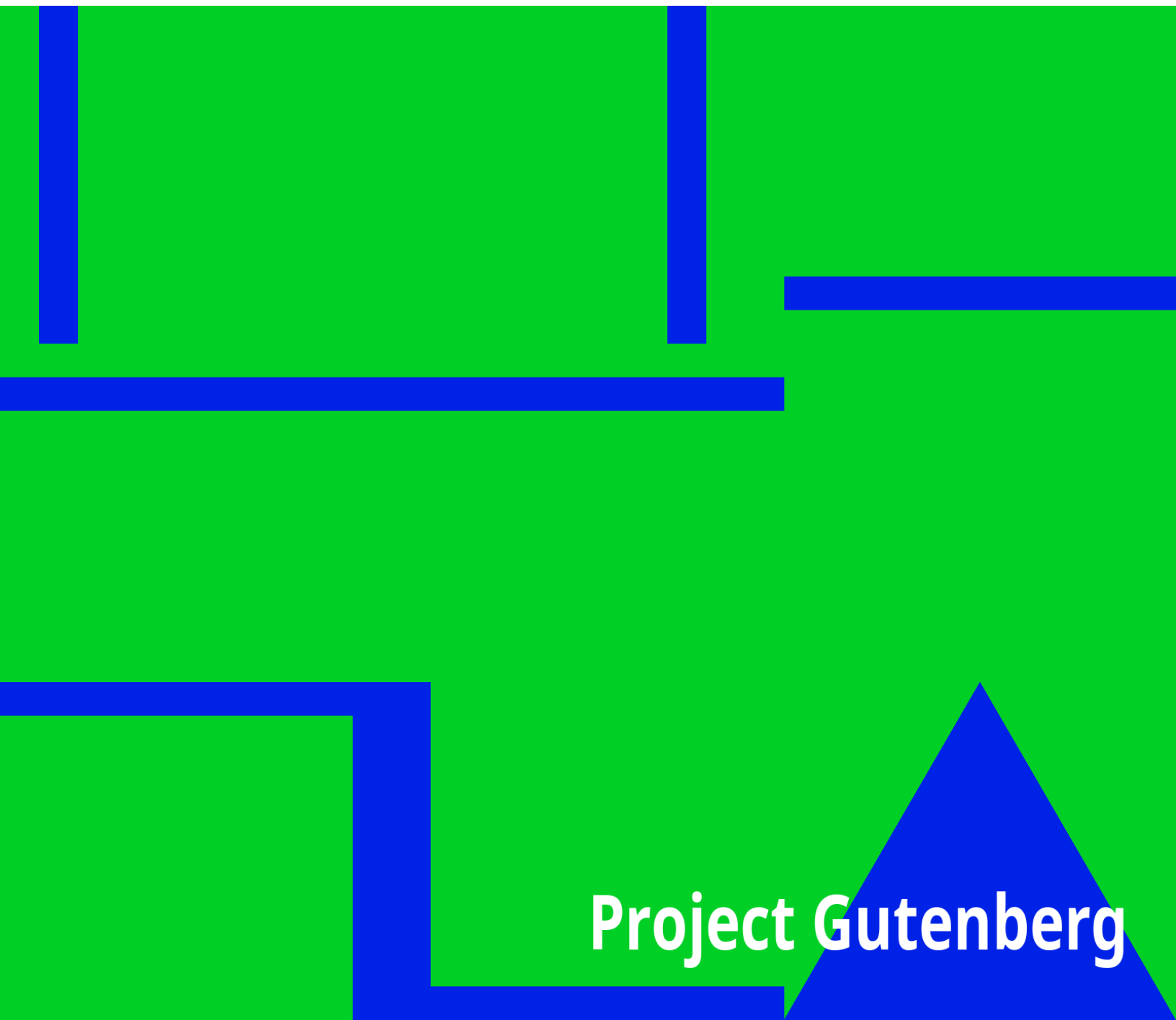


Three plays

Lawing and jawing; Forty yards; Woofing

Zora Neale Hurston

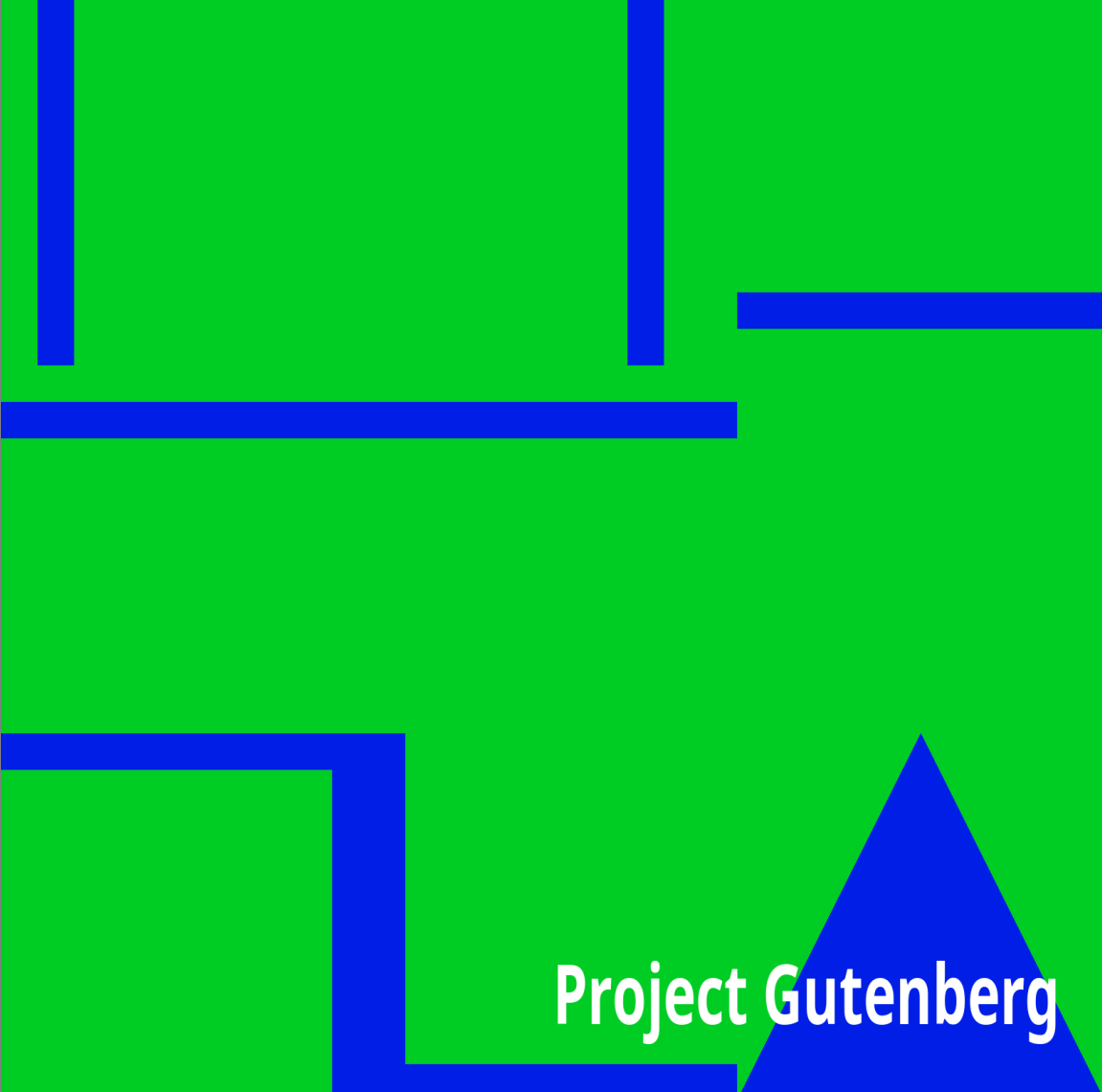
An abstract geometric design featuring a large green rectangle and a blue triangle. The green rectangle is composed of several smaller green shapes, including a large central rectangle and a smaller one to its right. The blue triangle is located in the bottom right corner, pointing upwards. The text "Project Gutenberg" is written in white on the blue triangle.

Project Gutenberg

Three plays

Lawing and jawing; Forty yards; Woofing

Zora Neale Hurston

An abstract geometric design featuring a large green rectangle. Overlaid on this are several blue shapes: two vertical bars on the left, a horizontal bar on the right, a horizontal bar across the middle, a large L-shaped bar at the bottom left, and a triangle at the bottom right. The text 'Project Gutenberg' is written in white on the blue triangle.

Project Gutenberg

The Project Gutenberg eBook of Three plays

This eBook is for the use of anyone anywhere in the United States and most other parts of the world at no cost and with almost no restrictions whatsoever. You may copy it, give it away or re-use it under the terms of the Project Gutenberg License included with this eBook or online at www.gutenberg.org. If you are not located in the United States, you will have to check the laws of the country where you are located before using this eBook.

Title: Three plays

Lawing and jawing; Forty yards; Woofing

Author: Zora Neale Hurston

Release date: November 29, 2005 [eBook #17187]

Most recently updated: December 13, 2020

Language: English

Other information and formats: www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/17187

Credits: E-text prepared by Charlene Taylor and the Project Gutenberg

Online Distributed Proofreading Team (<https://www.pgdp.net>)

from page images generously provided by the American Memory
Project of the Library of Congress

(<http://memory.loc.gov/ammem/>)

*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THREE PLAYS

E-text prepared by Charlene Taylor and the Project Gutenberg Online

Distributed Proofreading Team (<https://www.pgdp.net/>) from page images generously provided by the American Memory Project of the Library of Congress (<http://memory.loc.gov/ammem/>)

Note: These plays have been transcribed from original manuscripts. There are pencilled notations possibly by Ms. Hurston herself. These pencilled notations have been transcribed as *[Handwritten:(text)], with the exception of things that were clearly corrected typing mistakes. Uncorrected typographical errors were left as in the original. Words which were underlined in the text are enclosed by underscores ("_").

Images of the original pages are available through the American Memory Collection of the Library of Congress.

For "Lawing and Jawing" see

[http://memory.loc.gov/cgi-bin/query/S?
ammem/hurstonbib:@field\(TITLE+@od1\(Lawing+and+Jawing\)\)](http://memory.loc.gov/cgi-bin/query/S?ammem/hurstonbib:@field(TITLE+@od1(Lawing+and+Jawing)))

For "Forty Yards" see

[http://memory.loc.gov/cgi-bin/query/S?
ammem/hurstonbib:@field\(TITLE+@od1\(Forty+Yards\)\)](http://memory.loc.gov/cgi-bin/query/S?ammem/hurstonbib:@field(TITLE+@od1(Forty+Yards)))

For "Woofing" see

[http://memory.loc.gov/cgi-bin/query/S?
ammem/hurstonbib:@field\(TITLE+@od1\(Woofing\)\)](http://memory.loc.gov/cgi-bin/query/S?ammem/hurstonbib:@field(TITLE+@od1(Woofing)))

THREE PLAYS

Lawing and Jawing
Forty Yards
Woofing

by

Zora Neale Hurston

LAWING AND JAWING

by Zora *[Handwritten: (Neale)] Hurston

TIME: Present

PLACE: Way cross Georgia

SCENE: Judge Dunfummy's Court.

PERSONS: Judge Dunfumy, Officer Simpson and another, Jemima Flapcakes, Cliff Mullins, John Barnes, two lawyers, a clerk, a pretty girl and her escort.

SETTING: Usual court-room arrangement, except that there is a large red arrow pointing off-stage left, marked "To Jail."

ACTION: At rise everybody is in place except the Judge. Suddenly the CLERK looks off-stage right and motions for everybody to rise. Enter the JUDGE. He wears a black cap and gown and has his gavel in his hand. The two POLICEMEN walk behind him holding up his gown. He mounts the bench and glares all about him before he seats himself. There is a PRETTY GIRL in the front row left, and he takes a good look at her, smiles, frowns at her escort. He motions the police to leave him and take their places with the spectators and he then raps vigorously with his gavel for order.

JUDGE

Hear! Hear! Court is set! My honor is on de bench. You moufy folks set up!

(He glares at the boy with the pretty girl)

All right, Mr. Whistle-britches, just keep up dat jawing now and see how much time I'll give you!

BOY

I wasn't talking, your honor.

JUDGE Well, quit looking so moufy. (to CLERK) Call de first case. And I warn each and all dat my honor is in bad humor dis mawnin'. I'd give a

canary bird twenty years for peckin' at a elephant. (to CLERK) Bring 'em on.

CLERK

(Reading)

Cliff Mullins, charged with assault upon his wife with a weapon and disturbing the peace.

(As CLIFF is led to the bar by the officer, the JUDGE glares ferociously at the prisoner. His wife, all bandages, limps up to the bar at the same time.)

JUDGE So youse one of dese hard-boiled wife-beaters, huh? Just a mean old woman-Jessie! If I don't lay a hearing on you, God's a gopher! Now what *made* you cut such a caper?

CLIFF

Judge, I didn't go hunt her. Saturday night I was down on Dearborn Street in a nasty ditch *[Handwritten: nasty ditch crossed out in pencil, (buffet flat)]—

JUDGE

A nasty ditch? *[Handwritten: A nasty ditch crossed out in pencil, (Buffet flat)]

CLIFF

Aw, at Emma Hayles' house.

JUDGE

Oh, yes. Go on.

CLIFF Well, (Points thumb at wife) she come down dere and claim I took her money and she claimed I wuz spending it on Emma.

CLIFF'S WIFE

And dat's just whut he was doing, too, Judge.

CLIFF AW, she's tellin' a great big ole Georgia lie, Judge. I wasn't spendin' no money of her'n.

WOMAN Yes he was, Judge. There wasn't no money for him to git *but* mine. He ain't hit a lick of work since God been to Macon. Know whut he 'lowed when I worry him 'bout workin'? Says he wouldn't take a job wid de Careless Love Lumber Company, puttin' out whut make you do me lak you do, do, do.

JUDGE

So, you goes for a sweet-back, do you?

CLIFF

Naw suh, Judge. I'd be glad to work if I could find a job.

JUDGE

How long you been outa work?

CLIFF

Seventeen years—

JUDGE

Seventeen years?

(to woman)

You been takin' keer of dis man for seventeen years?

WOMAN Naw, but he been so mean to me, it seems lak seventeen years.

JUDGE

Now you tell me just where he hurt you.

WOMAN

Judge, tell you de truth, I'm hurt all over.

(Rubs her buttocks)

Fact is I'm cut.

JUDGE

Did you git cut in de fracas?

WOMAN

(feeling the back of her left thigh
below her buttocks)

Not in de fracas, Judge—just below it.

(She starts to show the JUDGE where
she has been cut. He motions to stop
her.)

JUDGE

Stop!

(to Officer Simpson)

Grab him. Put him in de shade.

CLIFF

Judge, I'm unguilty! I ain't laid de weight of my hand on her in malice.

You got me 'cused of murder and I ain't harmed a child.

JUDGE Lemme ast *you* something. Didn't you know dat all de women in dis town belongs to me? Beat my women and I'll stuff you in jail. 90 years. Take 'im away. (CLIFF is led off to jail. JUDGE looks angrily at the boy who is holding hands with the pretty girl) You runs me hot and I'm just dyin' to sit on yo' case. Whut you in here for?

BOY

Nothin'.

JUDGE

Well, whut you doin' in my court, you gater-faced rascal?

BOY My girl wanted to see whut was goin' on, so I brought her in.

JUDGE

Oh yeah!

(Smiles at GIRL)

She was usin' good sense to come see whut I'm doin', but how come *you* come in here? You gointer have a hard time gittin' out.

BOY I ain't done a thing. I ain't never done nothin'. I'm just as clean as a fish, and he been bathin' all his life.

JUDGE You ain't done nothin', hunh? Well den youse guilty of vacancy. Grab 'im, Simpson, and search 'im—and if he got any concealed weapons, I'm gointer give 'im life-time and eight years mo'. (The OFFICER seizes the boy and frisks him. All he finds is a new deck of cards. The JUDGE looks at them in triumph.) Unh hunh! I knowed it, one of dese skin game jelly-beans. Robbin' hard workin' men out they money.

BOY

Judge, I ain't used 'em at all. See, dey's brand new.

JUDGE Well, den youse charged wid totin' concealed cards and attempt to gamble. Ten years at hard labor. Put him in de dark, Simpson, and throw de key away. (He looks at the girl and beams.) Don't you worry bout how you gointer git home. You gointer be took home right, 'cause I'm gointer take you myself. Bring on de next one, clerk.

CLERK Jemima Flap-Cakes, charged with illegal possession and sale of alcoholic liquors.

JUDGE (She is a fat, black, belligerent looking woman. JUDGE looks coldly at her.) Well, you heard whut he said. Is you guilty or unguilty? And I'm tellin' you right now dat you come up befo' *me* it's just like youse in church. You better have a strong determination, and you better tell a good experience.

JEMIMA

(Arms akimbo)

Yes, I sold it and I'll sell it again.

(snaps fingers and shakes hips)

How does ole booze-selling mama talk?

JUDGE

Yes, five thousand dollars and ten years in jail.

(Snaps fingers and shakes hips)

How does ole heavy fining papa talk?

(She is led away, shouting and weeping)

CLERK

De Otis Blunt, charged wid stealin' a mule.

(LAWYER arises and comes forward with the prisoner)

LAWYER

You can't convict this man. I'm here to represent him.

JUDGE

Yo' mouf might spout lak a coffee pot but I got a lawyer

(Looks at other lawyer)

dat kin beat your segastuatin'.

(Looks admiring at girl)

How am I chewin' my dictionary and minglin' my alphabets?

LAWYER

Well, I kin try, can't I?

JUDGE

Oh yeah, you kin try, but I kin see right now where he's gointer git all de time dat God ever made dat ain't been used already. From now on.

(To LAWYER)

Go 'head, and spread yo' lungs all over Georgy, but he's goin' to jail!
Mules *must* be respected.

LAWYER

(Striking a pose at the bar)

Your Honor,

(Looks at the pretty girl)

Ladies and Gentlemen—

JUDGE

Never mind 'bout dat lady. You talk yo' chat to *me*.

LAWYER This is a clear case of syllogism! Again I say syllogism. My client is innocent because it was a dark night when they say he stole the mule and that's against all laws of syllogism. (JUDGE looks impressed and laughs)

JUDGE

Dat ole fool do know somethin' 'bout law.

LAWYER When George Washington was pleading de case of Marbury vs. Madison, what did *he* say? What *did* he say? Scintillate, scintillate, Globule orific. Fain would I fathom thy nature's specific. Loftily poised in ether capacious, strongly resembling a gem carbonacious. What did Abraham Lincoln say about mule-stealing? When torrid Phoebus refuses his presence and ceases to lamp with fierce incandescence, then you illumine the regions supernal, scintillate, scintillate, semper nocturnal. Syllogism, again I say syllogism. (He takes his seat amid applause)

JUDGE

Man, youse a pleadin' fool. You knows yo' rules and by-laws.

OTHER LAWYER

Let me show my glory. Let me spread my habeas corpus.

JUDGE

'Tain't no use. Dis lawyer done convinced me.

OTHER LAWYER

But, lemme parade my material—

JUDGE

Parade yo' material anywhere you wants to exceptin' befo' me. Dis lil girl wants to go home and I'm goin' with her and enjoy de consequences. Court's adjourned.

CURTAIN

"FORTY YARDS"

by

ZORA *[Handwritten: (Neale)] HURSTON

"FORTY YARDS"

(A Negro
football
game with
the popular
concept of
Negro life)

TIME: Present

PLACE: Washington, D.C.

SCENE: The Ball Park

PERSONS: The Howard and Lincoln teams, the Howard band, cheer leaders, spectators.

SETTING: The park with grandstands on either sides and up-stage.

ACTION: At rise, the grandstands are full, the cheer leaders are violently gyrating to whip up the mob. The Lincoln colors fly from the right. The

Howard from the left. Both have cheer leaders. First is heard the Lincoln mob singing "DIDN'T HE RAMBLE, RAMBLE."

Lincoln Mob

And didn't he ramble, ramble, ramble all around, in and out of town
He rambled, he rambled, rambled till Ol' Lincoln cut him down

Howard Mob

There'll be nothing but sweetmeats, for our football team
There'll be nothing but sweetmeats for our football team
Baked Hampton, boiled Shaw, fried Union, Lincoln Slaw,
There'll be nothing but sweetmeats, for our football team.

(Enter the HOWARD BAND, led by a
hot-strutting drum major. They parade
the field and the men students pile
down and fall in behind the team.
They sing and shout to the TEAM
SONG:)

This is the t-e-a-m team
On which the hopes of Howard lean
Beat Ol' Hampton, beat Ol' Union
Sweep Ol' Lincoln clean

We are the b-e-s-t best
Of the r-e-s-t rest
Come and watch us put Ol' Howard
On top of Lincoln's chest.

We'll hit the l-i-n-e line
For a hundred ninety-nine
For we love Ol' Howard, yes we love her
All the t-i-m-e time.

(At the
conclusion
the teams
takes the
field. The
ball is put
into play and
LINCOLN
kicks off to
Howard. As
the ball is
caught and
when the
player who is
carrying the
ball plunges,
followed by
his team, the
Lincoln
players fall
on their
knees and
begin to sing
I
COULDN'T
HEAR

NOBODY
PRAY. The
HOWARD
team charges
down
shouting
Joshua fit de
battle of
Jericho.
Whenever a
player is
tackled there
is a duet of
dancing.
Every step is
a dance.
Finally the
grandstand
catches fire
and the
dancing and
the shouting
runs riot up
there. When
the ball is on
Lincoln's ten-
yard line,
they hold
Howard there
by rounding

up both
teams into a
huddle and
the bunch-
shout and
sing to a
QUICK
CURTAIN.)

CURTAIN

LINCOLN'S PRAYER:

Ah, ah, they shall not ah pass us
Lord, Lord, Lord, Lord
They shall not pass us, Ah-h-h-h.

*[Handwritten (Jul. 21, 1931)]

"WOOFING"

By

ZORA *[Handwritten (Neale)] HURSTON

"WOOFING"

TIME: Present.

PLACE: Negro Street in Waycross, Ga.

PERSONS: Loungers, two children, guitar players, women, band—

SETTING: Porch and side walk, etc.

ACTION: Thru the open window of 'one' of the shacks a WOMAN is discovered ironing. A MAN is sitting on the floor of the porch asleep. She hums a bar or two, then comes to the window and calls to the man.

Woman Good Black, why don't you git up from dere and carry dese white folks clothes home? You always want money but you wouldn't hit a lick at a snake!

Man Aw, shut up woman. I'm tired of hearin' bout dem white folks clothes. I don't keer if dey never git 'em.

Woman

You better keer! Dese very clothes took and brought *you* out de crack. 'Cause de first time I saw you you was so hungry till you was walkin' lap-legged. Man, you had de white-mouf, you was so hungry.

(Enter another MAN leisurely. Good
Black sees him and calls)

Good Black

Hey, Cliffert, where you headed for?

Cliffert

Oh, no where in particular.

Good Black Come here then, fish, and lemme bend a checker game over yo' head. Come on, youse my fish.

Cliffert

(Comes to the porch and sits)

Git de checkers and I'll have you any, some or none. I push a mean chuck-a-luck myself.

Woman

(Voice inside quarreling)

Dress up and strut around! Yes! Play checkers? Yes! Eat? Yes! Work? No!!

(The game starts. A period of silence in which they indicate their concentration by frowns, cautious moves, head scratching.

GOOD
BLACK is pointing his index finger over the board indicating moves. He wig-wags, starts to move,

scratches his
head
thoroughly,
changes his
mind and fools
around without
moving)

Cliffert

Police! Police! Come here and make dis man move!

Good Black

Aw, I got plenty moves.

(Scratches his head)

Jus' tryin' to see which one I want to make. But when I do move, it's
gointer be just too bad for you.

(A guitar is heard off stage and
Cliffert brightens. He cups his hand
and calls)

Cliffert Hey Lonnie! Come here! Ha, ha, ha! I got me a fish. (Enter
LONNIE picking "East Coast" on his box and stands watching the game.
He ceases to play as he stops walking) Ha, ha! You see ol' Good Black goes
for a hard guy. He tries to know more than a mule and a mule's head
longer'n his'n. Ha, ha! I set a trap for him and he fell right in it. Trying to
ride de britches! Now look at him.

Good Black

Aw, shut up! You tryin' to show yo' grandma how to milk ducks. You can't
beat me playin' no checkers.

(Scratches his head again)

Just watch me show my glory.

Woman

(Leans out of window)

Good Black! When you gointer come git dese clothes!

(He does not answer, he is trying to
concentrate)

Lonnie You got him Cliffert. You got him in Louisville Loop. He's yo'
fish all right.

Cliffert

(Boastfully)

Man, didn't I push a mean chuck-a-luck dat time! I'm good, better, and
best. Move, Man!

(To Good Black)

I tole you not to do it.

Good Black

All dat noise ain't playin' checkers. You just wait till I make my move.

Woman All right, now, Mr. Nappy-Chin! I don't want to have to call you
no mo' to come keer dese white folks clothes! I'm tired of takin' and takin'
affa you! My belly's full clear up to de neck. I don't need no lazy coon lak
you nohow. I'm a good woman, and I needs somebody dats gointer give aid
and assistance.

Good Black,

Aw, go head on', woman, and leave me be! Every Saturday it's de same
thing! Yo' mouth exhausting like a automobile. You worse than "cryin'
Emma". You kin whoop like de Seaboard and squall lak de Coast Line.

(Taps his head)

You ain't go all dat b'long to *you*, and nothin' dat b'long to nobody's else. You better leave me 'lone before you make a bad man out of me. Fool wid me and I'll go git me somebody else. I'm a much-right man.

Woman Now you ain't no much right man neither. You didn't *git me* wid no saw-mill license—You went to de court house and paid a dollar and a half for me. Tain't no other woman got as much right to you as I got. De Man to tell you youse divorced befo' yo' kin play dat much-right on me!

Good Black

De Man don't have to tell me nothin'! I got divorce in my heels.

Woman You ain't de only one dat knows where de railroad track is, I done made up my mind, and I done promised Gabriel and a couple of other men dat if yo' don't do no better than yo' been doin', I'm gointer pack me a suit case and grab de first smoky thing I see. I'll be long gone.

Good Black Aw, yo' ain't no trouble! Yo' can be had. Yo' ain't never gointer leave me.

Woman How come I won't? Just 'cause I been takin' keer of yo', don't make a park ape out yo'self. I'll leave yo', just as sure as yo' snore!

Good Black

(Rises and hitches up his trousers)

Aw, yo' ain't gointer leave me, and if yo' go, yo' wouldn't stay, 'cause I'm a damn sweet man, and yo' know it!

Lonnie

Hey, Hey!

(He begins to pick and Good Black

sings. Lonnie sings a line now and then)

Good Black

Yo' may leave and go to Hali-muh-fack
But my slow drag will—uh bring yo' back
Well yo' may go, but this will bring yo' back

I been in de country but I moved to town
I'm a tolo-shaker from my head on down
Well, yo' may go, but this will bring yo' back

Some folks call me a tolo-shaker
It's a doggone lie I'm a back-bone breaker
Well, yo' may go, but this will bring yo' back.

Oh, ship on de sea, boat on de ocean
I raise hell when I take a notion
Well, yo' may go, but this will bring yo' back.

Oh, who do, who do, who do wackin'
Wid my hells a' poppin' and my toe-nails crackin'
Well, yo' may go, but this will bring yo' back.

Woman Dat's all right too, pap but if yo' can't make me tote dese clothes home, don't bring de mess up. Yo'se abstificaly a humbug.

Cliffert

Man, come on back here and move, or else own up to de folks yo' can't push no checkers wid me.

(He sits and begins to lay out moves
with his fingers and scratch his head.

Enter another MAN and stands akimbo
looking over Cliff's shoulder)

Cliff

(Looking up)

Don't stand over me lak dat, ugly as yo' is.

Man (Skanko)

You ain't nobody's pretty baby yo'self!

Cliff Dat's all right, I ain't as ugly as yo'—youse ugly enough to git behind a Simpoon weed and hatch monkeys.

Man (Skanko)

And youse ugly enough to git behind a tombstone and hatch hants.

Cliff Youse so ugly dey have to cover yo' face up at night so sleep can slip up on yo'.

Man (Skanko)

You look like ten cents worth of Have-Mercy. Yo' face look lak ole Uncle Jump-off. Yo' mouth look lak a bunch of ruffles.

Cliff Yeah, but yo' done passed me. Yo' so ugly till they could throw yo' in de Mississippi River and skim ugly for six months.

Man (Skanko) Look here, Cliff, don't yo' personate me! Counting from de little finger back to de thumb—yo' start anythin', I go yo' some.

Cliff Go head and grab me buddie, but if yo' don't know how to turn me loose too, don't bring de mess up! If yo' hit me, I may not beat you, but yo'll be so dirty when St. Peter git yo' dat he can't use yo'.

Man (Skanko) Don't call *me* buddy. Yo' buddy is huntin' coconuts. Don't yo' try to throw me for a nap. Do. I'll kill yo' so stiff dead they'll have to push yo' down. Yo' gointer to make me do some double cussin' on you. (He picks up a heavy stick and walks back towards Cliff) Now I got dis farmer's choice in my hands, yo' better git outa my face.

Cliff

Yo' wanta fight?

Man

Yeah I wanta fight. Put it where I kin use it and I'll sho' use it. I'll fight anybody. I get so hot sometimes I fights de corner of de house. I'm so hot I totes a pistol to keep from gettin' in a fight wid myself. I prints dangerous every time I sit down in, in a chair.

Cliff Man, this ain't no fighting weather. Ha, ha, ha! Did yo' think I was mad sho' nuff? Yo' can't fight me. They's got to be runnin' before fightin' and they's got to be plenty *good* runnin' before dis fight comes off.

Man All right now. Yo' leave me alone and I'm a *good* man. I'm just like an old shoe. If yo' rain on me and cool me off I'm soft! If yo' shine on me and git me hot, I'm hard. (He drops the stick and exits)

(Cliff is
shaking all
over. He looks
after the Man
to be sure he is
gone)

Good Black Kah, kah, kah. Whut yo' so scarred about? De way yo' was talkin' I though yo' was mad enough to fight.

Cliff I was. I gits hot real quick! But I'm very easy cooled when de man I'm mad wid is bigger'n me. (He drops into his seat, wiping his face) Man did yo' see how he grabbed up dat check? He done skeered me into a three-week's spasm!

Good Black's Wife
Good Black, dese clothes is still waiting.

Good Black Well, let 'em wait on, I done tole yo' once. Yo' kind run yo' mouf but yo' can't run my business.

(Enter a PRETTY GIRL. She strolls happily across without stopping. Good Black pretends to cough)

Good Black
Who is dat?

Girl
(Turns and glares at him)
My old man got something for dat cough yo' got.

Cliff Dat's right, tell dese old mullet hear married men to mind they own business. Now, take *me* for instance. I'm a much-right man. (Gets up and approaches her flirtatiously) I didn't quite git yo' name straight. Yo' better tell it to me again.

Girl
My name is Bee Ethel, turned round to Jones.

Cliff
(Flirtatiously)
Yo' pretty lil ole ground angel yo'? Where did yo' come from?

Bee Ethel
Detroit. Yo' like me?

Cliff Do I lak yo'? I love yo' just lak God loves Gabriel, and dat's his best angel. Go 'head and say somethin'. I jus' love to hear yo' talk.

Bee Ethel
Gimme five dollars. I need some stockings.

Cliff *Now* Mama, dis ain't Gimme, Ga. Dis is Waycross. I'm just lak de cemetery. I takes in but never no put out. I ain't puttin' out nothin' but old folks eyes—and I don't do that till they's dead. Run long, mama. (The girl exits and he resumes his seat)

Cliff
Come on, Good Black, lemme wrap dis checker roun yo' neck.

Good Black
Gimme time, gimme time! Don't try to rush me.
(He begins same business of figuring
out moves and scratching his head)

(Enter two or three girls and fellows.
The girls are dressed in cool summer
dresses, but nothing elaborate)

Lonnie
I know I'm gointer play something now.
(He tunes and plays "Cold Rainy Day".
He begins to sing and the others join
in. Not all. But all start to dancing.
They couple off as far as possible and

Lindy. The men unmated do hot solo
steps. The men cry out in ecstasy)

1. Shimmy! If you can't shimmy, shake your head.

2. Look, baby, look! Throw it in de alley

3. Look, if you can't look, stick out, and if you can't stick
out, git out.

(At the end of the song and dance, one
of the girls exclaim)

Girl

Aw, we got to go. Mama's looking for us.

(The three girls exit, walking
happily. The men watch them go)

Cliff

Oh boy, look at 'em! Switching it and looking back at it.

(He imitates the girl's walk)

Good Black

Yeah Lawd, ain't they specifyin'! They handles a lot of traffic.

Cliff

(Seating himself again)

Yeah, but dat don't play no checkers. Come on here, Good Black
and lemme finish wearing your ant.

Good Black's Wife

Good Black, yo' better come git dese clothes.

Lonnie

Good Black, yo' wife kin cold whoop for what she want.

Good Black

Yeah and if she don't git, she keep right on whoopin'. B'lieve I wants a drink of water. Wisht I knowed where I could slip up on me a drink.

Cliff Aw man, come on back here and move. Yo' doin' everythin' but playin' checkers. You'd ruther move a mountain wid a pry bar than to move (Points) dat man.

Good Black

(Seats himself)

Lemme hurry up and beat dis game befo' yo' bust yo' britches.

(He wags his finger to indicate moves, scratches his head, but doesn't move.

Several men enter and group around the players. All offer suggestions. One says, "you got him Cliffert. He's locked up just as tight as a keyhole".

Another: "Aw, man he kin break out!"

Another: "Yeah, but it'll cost him plenty to git out of dat trap".)

Cliff

Police! Police! He won't move!

Another Voice

Aw, leave go de checkers and less shoot some crap.

(Enter a WOMAN in a house dress, head rag on, run down house shoes. She goes to the edge of the porch and calls inside)

Woman

Him there Bertha, what yo' doin'.

Woman Inside Still bumpin' de white folks clothes—hittin' for de sundown man. Come on in and have some sit down.

Outside Woman Ain't got time. Got a house full of company. I took a minute to see if yo' could let me have a little skeeting garret.

Inside Woman

How come yo' didn't git yo'self some snuff whilst yo' was at de store? De man ast yo' what else. I ain't no Piggly Wiggly. Reckon I kin spare yo' a dip tho.

(She hands out the box and the outside woman fills her lip and hands it back)

Outside Woman Much obliged, I thank yo'. Reckon I better heel and toe it on back, to see how de comp'ny is makin' out.

Inside Woman

Step inside a minute I want to put a bug in yo' ear.

(She makes an urgent gesture and the other woman goes inside)

(Lonnie is
sitting off to
himself and

picking
"Rabbit on de
Log" softly. A
small BOY
dashes on with
a lolly pop in
his hand. He is
licking it and
laughing. He is
pursued by a
little GIRL
yelling "you
gimme my all
day sucker!
Johnny! You
gimme my
candy, now!"
They run all
over the stage.
The men take
notice of them
and one of
them seizes
the boy and
restores the
candy to the
girl. She pokes
out her tongue
at the boy and
says "goody,

goody, goody,
goody,
goody!" She
notes the
guitar playing
and begins to
dance. The
boy makes
faces back at
her and dances
back at her.
The music gets
louder,
dancing faster,
check board
gets upset.
General
laughter at
that. When
dance is over,
boy snatches
the lolly pop
again and
races away and
the girl runs
behind him
yelling
"Johnny! You
gimme my
candy!

Johnny!" The
music stops
and the crap
game gets
under way.
Furious side
bets for 5 and
10 cents each.
Loud calls on
Miss "Daisy
Dice", snake
eyes, "Ada
from Decatur".
Somebody
suggests a soft
roll, others
object on the
ground that it's
too easy for
the experts to
cheat)

Good Black

Gimme de dice! I'm gointer play 'em like John Henry.

Lonnie

John Henry didn't bother wid de bones. He used to play Georgy Skin.

Good Black He shot crap too. He played everythin' and everythin' he played, he played it good. Just like he uster drive steel. If I could whip steel like John Henry, I wouldn't stay here and nowhere else.

Cliff

Whut would yo' do?

Good Black

I'd go somewhere and keep books for somebody.

Lonnie

I know how to play John Henry.

Good Black

Well, turn it on and let de bad luck happen.

(As Lonnie plays thru a verse warming
up, all the men get interested and
start to hum. Cliffert shouts out)

Cliff

Lawd, Lawd, what evil have I done)

(They sing John Henry. At the close,
the woman who came to borrow snuff
emerges from the house still talking
back at the woman inside)

Woman

He ain't no trouble. I tole him, I says, "yo' must think youse de man
dat made side meat taste lak ham." See yo' later.

(She exits hurriedly. The crap game
goes on until a band is heard
approaching)

Lonnie

Who dead?

Cliff Nobody. Don't you know de Imperial Elks is goin' to New York to de Elks Grand Lodge? Yeah, bo, and they's takin' they band. Dat's supposed to be de *finest* band in de United States. (The band approaches followed by a great crow. The crap game is instantly deserted and all follow the band)

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THREE PLAYS ***

Updated editions will replace the previous one—the old editions will be renamed.

Creating the works from print editions not protected by U.S. copyright law means that no one owns a United States copyright in these works, so the Foundation (and you!) can copy and distribute it in the United States without permission and without paying copyright royalties. Special rules, set forth in the General Terms of Use part of this license, apply to copying and distributing Project Gutenberg™ electronic works to protect the PROJECT GUTENBERG™ concept and trademark. Project Gutenberg is a registered trademark, and may not be used if you charge for an eBook, except by following the terms of the trademark license, including paying royalties for use of the Project Gutenberg trademark. If you do not charge anything for copies of this eBook, complying with the trademark license is very easy. You may use this eBook for nearly any purpose such as creation of derivative works, reports, performances and research. Project Gutenberg eBooks may be modified and printed and given away—you may do practically ANYTHING in the United States with eBooks not protected by U.S. copyright law. Redistribution is subject to the trademark license, especially commercial redistribution.

START: FULL LICENSE

THE FULL PROJECT GUTENBERG™ LICENSE

PLEASE READ THIS BEFORE YOU DISTRIBUTE OR USE THIS WORK

To protect the Project Gutenberg™ mission of promoting the free distribution of electronic works, by using or distributing this work (or any other work associated in any way with the phrase “Project Gutenberg”), you agree to comply with all the terms of the Full Project Gutenberg License available with this file or online at www.gutenberg.org/license.

Section 1. General Terms of Use and Redistributing Project Gutenberg electronic works

1.A. By reading or using any part of this Project Gutenberg electronic work, you indicate that you have read, understand, agree to and accept all the terms of this license and intellectual property (trademark/copyright) agreement. If you do not agree to abide by all the terms of this agreement, you must cease using and return or destroy all copies of Project Gutenberg electronic works in your possession. If you paid a fee for obtaining a copy of or access to a Project Gutenberg electronic work and you do not agree to be bound by the terms of this agreement, you may obtain a refund from the person or entity to whom you paid the fee as set forth in paragraph 1.E.8.

1.B. “Project Gutenberg” is a registered trademark. It may only be used on or associated in any way with an electronic work by people who agree to be bound by the terms of this agreement. There are a few things that you can do with most Project Gutenberg electronic works even without complying with the full terms of this agreement. See paragraph 1.C below. There are a lot of things you can do with Project Gutenberg electronic works if you follow the terms of this agreement and help preserve free future access to Project Gutenberg electronic works. See paragraph 1.E below.

1.C. The Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation (“the Foundation” or PGLAF), owns a compilation copyright in the collection of Project Gutenberg electronic works. Nearly all the individual works in the collection are in the public domain in the United States. If an individual work is unprotected by copyright law in the United States and you are

located in the United States, we do not claim a right to prevent you from copying, distributing, performing, displaying or creating derivative works based on the work as long as all references to Project Gutenberg are removed. Of course, we hope that you will support the Project Gutenberg mission of promoting free access to electronic works by freely sharing Project Gutenberg works in compliance with the terms of this agreement for keeping the Project Gutenberg name associated with the work. You can easily comply with the terms of this agreement by keeping this work in the same format with its attached full Project Gutenberg License when you share it without charge with others.

1.D. The copyright laws of the place where you are located also govern what you can do with this work. Copyright laws in most countries are in a constant state of change. If you are outside the United States, check the laws of your country in addition to the terms of this agreement before downloading, copying, displaying, performing, distributing or creating derivative works based on this work or any other Project Gutenberg work. The Foundation makes no representations concerning the copyright status of any work in any country other than the United States.

1.E. Unless you have removed all references to Project Gutenberg:

1.E.1. The following sentence, with active links to, or other immediate access to, the full Project Gutenberg License must appear prominently whenever any copy of a Project Gutenberg work (any work on which the phrase “Project Gutenberg” appears, or with which the phrase “Project Gutenberg” is associated) is accessed, displayed, performed, viewed, copied or distributed:

This eBook is for the use of anyone anywhere in the United States and most other parts of the world at no cost and with almost no restrictions whatsoever. You may copy it, give it away or re-use it under the terms of the Project Gutenberg™ License included with this eBook or online at www.gutenberg.org. If you are not located in the United States, you will have to check the laws of the country where you are located before using this eBook.

1.E.2. If an individual Project Gutenberg electronic work is derived from texts not protected by U.S. copyright law (does not contain a notice indicating that it is posted with permission of the copyright holder), the work can be copied and distributed to anyone in the United States without paying any fees or charges. If you are redistributing or providing access to a work with the phrase “Project Gutenberg” associated with or appearing on the work, you must comply either with the requirements of paragraphs 1.E.1 through 1.E.7 or obtain permission for the use of the work and the Project Gutenberg trademark as set forth in paragraphs 1.E.8 or 1.E.9.

1.E.3. If an individual Project Gutenberg electronic work is posted with the permission of the copyright holder, your use and distribution must comply with both paragraphs 1.E.1 through 1.E.7 and any additional terms imposed by the copyright holder. Additional terms will be linked to the Project Gutenberg License for all works posted with the permission of the copyright holder found at the beginning of this work.

1.E.4. Do not unlink or detach or remove the full Project Gutenberg License terms from this work, or any files containing a part of this work or any other work associated with Project Gutenberg.

1.E.5. Do not copy, display, perform, distribute or redistribute this electronic work, or any part of this electronic work, without prominently displaying the sentence set forth in paragraph 1.E.1 with active links or immediate access to the full terms of the Project Gutenberg License.

1.E.6. You may convert to and distribute this work in any binary, compressed, marked up, nonproprietary or proprietary form, including any word processing or hypertext form. However, if you provide access to or distribute copies of a Project Gutenberg work in a format other than “Plain Vanilla ASCII” or other format used in the official version posted on the official Project Gutenberg website (www.gutenberg.org), you must, at no additional cost, fee or expense to the user, provide a copy, a means of exporting a copy, or a means of obtaining a copy upon request, of the work in its original “Plain Vanilla ASCII” or other form. Any alternate format must include the full Project Gutenberg License as specified in paragraph 1.E.1.

1.E.7. Do not charge a fee for access to, viewing, displaying, performing, copying or distributing any Project Gutenberg works unless you comply with paragraph 1.E.8 or 1.E.9.

1.E.8. You may charge a reasonable fee for copies of or providing access to or distributing Project Gutenberg electronic works provided that:

- You pay a royalty fee of 20% of the gross profits you derive from the use of Project Gutenberg works calculated using the method you already use to calculate your applicable taxes. The fee is owed to the owner of the Project Gutenberg trademark, but he has agreed to donate royalties under this paragraph to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation. Royalty payments must be paid within 60 days following each date on which you prepare (or are legally required to prepare) your periodic tax returns. Royalty payments should be clearly marked as such and sent to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation at the address specified in Section 4, “Information about donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation.”
- You provide a full refund of any money paid by a user who notifies you in writing (or by e-mail) within 30 days of receipt that s/he does not agree to the terms of the full Project Gutenberg™ License. You must require such a user to return or destroy all copies of the works possessed in a physical medium and discontinue all use of and all access to other copies of Project Gutenberg™ works.
- You provide, in accordance with paragraph 1.F.3, a full refund of any money paid for a work or a replacement copy, if a defect in the electronic work is discovered and reported to you within 90 days of receipt of the work.
- You comply with all other terms of this agreement for free distribution of Project Gutenberg™ works.

1.E.9. If you wish to charge a fee or distribute a Project Gutenberg™ electronic work or group of works on different terms than are set forth in this agreement, you must obtain permission in writing from the Project

Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, the manager of the Project Gutenberg™ trademark. Contact the Foundation as set forth in Section 3 below.

1.F.

1.F.1. Project Gutenberg volunteers and employees expend considerable effort to identify, do copyright research on, transcribe and proofread works not protected by U.S. copyright law in creating the Project Gutenberg™ collection. Despite these efforts, Project Gutenberg™ electronic works, and the medium on which they may be stored, may contain “Defects,” such as, but not limited to, incomplete, inaccurate or corrupt data, transcription errors, a copyright or other intellectual property infringement, a defective or damaged disk or other medium, a computer virus, or computer codes that damage or cannot be read by your equipment.

1.F.2. LIMITED WARRANTY, DISCLAIMER OF DAMAGES - Except for the “Right of Replacement or Refund” described in paragraph 1.F.3, the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, the owner of the Project Gutenberg™ trademark, and any other party distributing a Project Gutenberg™ electronic work under this agreement, disclaim all liability to you for damages, costs and expenses, including legal fees. YOU AGREE THAT YOU HAVE NO REMEDIES FOR NEGLIGENCE, STRICT LIABILITY, BREACH OF WARRANTY OR BREACH OF CONTRACT EXCEPT THOSE PROVIDED IN PARAGRAPH 1.F.3. YOU AGREE THAT THE FOUNDATION, THE TRADEMARK OWNER, AND ANY DISTRIBUTOR UNDER THIS AGREEMENT WILL NOT BE LIABLE TO YOU FOR ACTUAL, DIRECT, INDIRECT, CONSEQUENTIAL, PUNITIVE OR INCIDENTAL DAMAGES EVEN IF YOU GIVE NOTICE OF THE POSSIBILITY OF SUCH DAMAGE.

1.F.3. LIMITED RIGHT OF REPLACEMENT OR REFUND - If you discover a defect in this electronic work within 90 days of receiving it, you can receive a refund of the money (if any) you paid for it by sending a written explanation to the person you received the work from. If you received the work on a physical medium, you must return the medium with your written explanation. The person or entity that provided you with the defective work may elect to provide a replacement copy in lieu of a refund.

If you received the work electronically, the person or entity providing it to you may choose to give you a second opportunity to receive the work electronically in lieu of a refund. If the second copy is also defective, you may demand a refund in writing without further opportunities to fix the problem.

1.F.4. Except for the limited right of replacement or refund set forth in paragraph 1.F.3, this work is provided to you ‘AS-IS’, WITH NO OTHER WARRANTIES OF ANY KIND, EXPRESS OR IMPLIED, INCLUDING BUT NOT LIMITED TO WARRANTIES OF MERCHANTABILITY OR FITNESS FOR ANY PURPOSE.

1.F.5. Some states do not allow disclaimers of certain implied warranties or the exclusion or limitation of certain types of damages. If any disclaimer or limitation set forth in this agreement violates the law of the state applicable to this agreement, the agreement shall be interpreted to make the maximum disclaimer or limitation permitted by the applicable state law. The invalidity or unenforceability of any provision of this agreement shall not void the remaining provisions.

1.F.6. INDEMNITY - You agree to indemnify and hold the Foundation, the trademark owner, any agent or employee of the Foundation, anyone providing copies of Project Gutenberg™ electronic works in accordance with this agreement, and any volunteers associated with the production, promotion and distribution of Project Gutenberg™ electronic works, harmless from all liability, costs and expenses, including legal fees, that arise directly or indirectly from any of the following which you do or cause to occur: (a) distribution of this or any Project Gutenberg work, (b) alteration, modification, or additions or deletions to any Project Gutenberg work, and (c) any Defect you cause.

Section 2. Information about the Mission of Project Gutenberg

Project Gutenberg is synonymous with the free distribution of electronic works in formats readable by the widest variety of computers including obsolete, old, middle-aged and new computers. It exists because of the

efforts of hundreds of volunteers and donations from people in all walks of life.

Volunteers and financial support to provide volunteers with the assistance they need are critical to reaching Project Gutenberg's goals and ensuring that the Project Gutenberg collection will remain freely available for generations to come. In 2001, the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation was created to provide a secure and permanent future for Project Gutenberg and future generations. To learn more about the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation and how your efforts and donations can help, see Sections 3 and 4 and the Foundation information page at www.gutenberg.org.

Section 3. Information about the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation

The Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation is a non-profit 501(c)(3) educational corporation organized under the laws of the state of Mississippi and granted tax exempt status by the Internal Revenue Service. The Foundation's EIN or federal tax identification number is 64-6221541. Contributions to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation are tax deductible to the full extent permitted by U.S. federal laws and your state's laws.

The Foundation's business office is located at 41 Watchung Plaza #516, Montclair NJ 07042, USA, +1 (862) 621-9288. Email contact links and up to date contact information can be found at the Foundation's website and official page at www.gutenberg.org/contact

Section 4. Information about Donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation

Project Gutenberg™ depends upon and cannot survive without widespread public support and donations to carry out its mission of increasing the number of public domain and licensed works that can be freely distributed in machine-readable form accessible by the widest array of equipment

including outdated equipment. Many small donations (\$1 to \$5,000) are particularly important to maintaining tax exempt status with the IRS.

The Foundation is committed to complying with the laws regulating charities and charitable donations in all 50 states of the United States. Compliance requirements are not uniform and it takes a considerable effort, much paperwork and many fees to meet and keep up with these requirements. We do not solicit donations in locations where we have not received written confirmation of compliance. To SEND DONATIONS or determine the status of compliance for any particular state visit www.gutenberg.org/donate.

While we cannot and do not solicit contributions from states where we have not met the solicitation requirements, we know of no prohibition against accepting unsolicited donations from donors in such states who approach us with offers to donate.

International donations are gratefully accepted, but we cannot make any statements concerning tax treatment of donations received from outside the United States. U.S. laws alone swamp our small staff.

Please check the Project Gutenberg web pages for current donation methods and addresses. Donations are accepted in a number of other ways including checks, online payments and credit card donations. To donate, please visit: www.gutenberg.org/donate.

Section 5. General Information About Project Gutenberg electronic works

Professor Michael S. Hart was the originator of the Project Gutenberg concept of a library of electronic works that could be freely shared with anyone. For forty years, he produced and distributed Project Gutenberg eBooks with only a loose network of volunteer support.

Project Gutenberg eBooks are often created from several printed editions, all of which are confirmed as not protected by copyright in the U.S. unless a

copyright notice is included. Thus, we do not necessarily keep eBooks in compliance with any particular paper edition.

Most people start at our website which has the main PG search facility:
www.gutenberg.org.

This website includes information about Project Gutenberg, including how to make donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, how to help produce our new eBooks, and how to subscribe to our email newsletter to hear about new eBooks.